



ReGen Civics
Quest Field Guide

Forest Communication

regencivics.earth

What This Quest Is

Build a real relationship with the trees near you. Not a walk in the woods — a relationship. Return to the same trees over time. Learn to read what you are seeing. Develop the habit of genuine attention. Visit at least once a week for three weeks or more.

Story Card

Trees communicate. That sentence would have seemed like poetry thirty years ago. Now it is science. Suzanne Simard's research showed that trees share carbon, water, and chemical signals through mycorrhizal networks underground. Old trees support younger trees. When a tree is stressed, it sends warning compounds through the network. We are poor at perceiving things that move and communicate at a different speed than us. But the capacity is there. It just requires slowing down. When you learn to listen to trees, you also learn something about what it means to listen to anything that is not shaped like you.

How To Do This Quest

Step 1: Find your trees.

Identify 2-3 trees within easy reach of your daily life. Find at least one old tree in the oldest accessible forest or parkland near you.

Step 2: Visit regularly.

Return to the same trees at least once a week. Same trees. Different weather, different light, different states of your own attention.

Step 3: Learn to read what you see.

Study bark patterns, canopy shape, root surface, presence of fungi and lichen. A local tree identification guide helps.

Step 4: Practice genuine attention.

On at least three visits, spend 20+ minutes doing nothing except being with one tree. Sit at its base. Put your hands on the bark. Follow the branches.

Step 5: Research the species.

How long do they live? How do they reproduce? What animals depend on them? What is their relationship to the soil and the water?

Step 6: Document your relationship.

Keep a field journal across your visits. Photos, observations, sketches. What did you notice this week that you did not notice last week?

Step 7: Share your account.

Write or record a piece about your relationship with these specific trees. What did you learn to see? What shifted in how you relate to the living world?

Deliverable

A documented account of your relationship with specific trees over at least three weeks, including what you learned to see and what changed.

Tips

- The old-growth forest floor is the most complete expression of a living mycorrhizal network you can walk on.
- Slow down more than you think you need to. Most of what we miss in nature we miss because we are moving too fast.
- Lichen on bark indicates clean air. Bracket fungi at the base indicate root decay.

Resources

- The Hidden Life of Trees by Peter Wohlleben
- Finding the Mother Tree by Suzanne Simard
- iNaturalist app for species ID and mycorrhizal research

A Place to Write

Your tree journal — observations from each visit:
